How to mark a 'd' question in Eduqas GCSE Religious Studies – updated for 2025/26

Eduqas GCSE Religious Studies comprises two assessment objectives, each worth 50% of the qualification. Assessment Objective 2 is assessed solely through 'd' questions, which ask candidates to analyse and evaluate a set statement. After each 'd' statement, there is the same rubric for all 'd' questions except 2d on Route A Component 1 and 1d on Route B Component 1. The rubric was updated in 2025/26 to make the language more accessible. This rubric is:

Discuss this statement.

Show that you have considered more than one point of view.

Refer to religious beliefs and teachings in your answer.

For 2d in Component 1 on Route A and 1d in Component 1 Route B, the rubric is as follows:

Discuss this statement.

Show that you have considered more than one point of view.

Refer to religious beliefs and teachings in your answer.

Refer to non-religious beliefs in your answer.

The rubric guides candidates towards what they should include in their responses, and the band descriptors match accordingly (included below). When marking, it is essential to use these descriptors to place responses into the correct band and then give a suitable mark.

Process for marking a 'd' question: a step-by-step guide

1. **Read the question and it's rubric.** As candidates should, look for key elements of the question that provide a more specific focus, such as 'all', 'any', 'most', 'never' etc. These give an indication of how the statement can be evaluated, e.g. rather than expecting a general evaluation of the pros and cons of abortion, if the statement was: **'Abortion should only be allowed when the mother's life is at risk.',** we would expect a focus on whether abortion is acceptable to save a mother's life. Therefore, a general answer evaluating abortion is more likely to be placed in the lower bands whereas an answer focusing on whether abortion is acceptable to save the mother's life, and whether this is the only acceptable reason or not, is more likely to be placed in higher bands.
2. **Read the indicative content included in the mark scheme.** This is content that the Principal Examiner expected candidates to include in their answers. The guidance to credit any alternative answers is always included, as there may well be candidates who include excellent, accurate information that isn't in the mark scheme, and they should not be penalised for doing so! In fact, it may well indicate an insightful response worthy of the higher bands (although this isn't always the case so always refer to the band descriptors). Re-read this indicative content before each time before you begin to mark 'd' questions (which is also good advice for other types of questions).
3. **Re-read the band descriptors and have them out as you mark** so that you can easily refer back to them.
4. **Read the answer carefully!** Keep in your mind all of the things noted above: the specific focus of the question; indicative content; band descriptor content.
5. **Decide on a band.** You may need to keep returning to look at the descriptors, especially for the first few responses each time you mark a set of 'd' answers. Bands are 'best fit'.

6. **Decide on a mark.** Consider how far into the band the answer is: if it is close to the band above because it includes one or two points from the higher band then place it at the top of the band. Likewise, if it fits that band but only just, place it at the bottom of the band.
7. On questions that require an additional mark for SPaG – **mark SPaG after marking the answer.** It is difficult to remember the content of an answer as well as the accuracy of SPaG and give both a fair and accurate mark at once. Mark the response itself first, following the steps above, and then re-read it for SPaG.
8. **Read the SPaG band descriptors (included below) and re-read the SPaG guidance booklet** before each time you begin to mark a 'd' question that also needs to be marked for SPaG.
9. **Highlight errors.** Don't highlight errors that could be a handwriting error rather than a SPaG error, such as a lower case 'c' for 'Christians'. Keep in mind that it is a mark for SPaG, which means it is not just spelling that has to be considered.
10. **Decide on a band** using the guidance in the SPaG booklet.
11. **Decide on a mark**.

Question 'd' (except 2d on Component 1 in Route A and 1d on Component 1 Route B)

Band	Band Descriptor	Mark Total
5	An excellent, highly detailed analysis and evaluation of the issue based on detailed knowledge of religion, religious teaching and moral reasoning to formulate judgements and present alternative or different viewpoints. An excellent understanding of how belief influences individuals, communities and societies. Uses and interprets religious/specialist language, terms and sources of wisdom and authority extensively, accurately and appropriately.	**13 – 15**
4	A very good, detailed analysis and evaluation of the issue based on accurate knowledge of religion, religious teaching and moral reasoning to formulate judgements and present alternative or different viewpoints. A very good understanding of how belief influences individuals, communities and societies. Uses and interprets religious/specialist language, terms and sources of wisdom and authority appropriately and in detail.	**10 – 12**
3	A good, generally detailed analysis and evaluation of the issue based on a generally accurate knowledge of religion, religious teaching and moral reasoning to formulate reasonable judgements and recognise alternative or different viewpoints. A good understanding of how belief influences individuals, communities and societies. Uses and interprets some religious/specialist language, terms and/or sources of wisdom and authority.	**7 – 9**
2	Limited statement(s) of more than one viewpoint based on limited knowledge of religion, religious teaching and moral reasoning to formulate judgements. A limited understanding of how belief influences individuals, communities and societies. Uses limited religious/specialist language, terms and/or few sources of wisdom and authority.	**4 – 6**
1	A poor, basic statement of a point of view and a very limited attempt or no attempt to formulate judgements or offer alternative or different viewpoints. Little attempt or no attempt made to demonstrate how belief influences individuals, communities and societies. Poor use or no use, of religious/specialist language, terms and/or sources of wisdom and authority.	**1 – 3**
0	No relevant point of view stated.	**0**

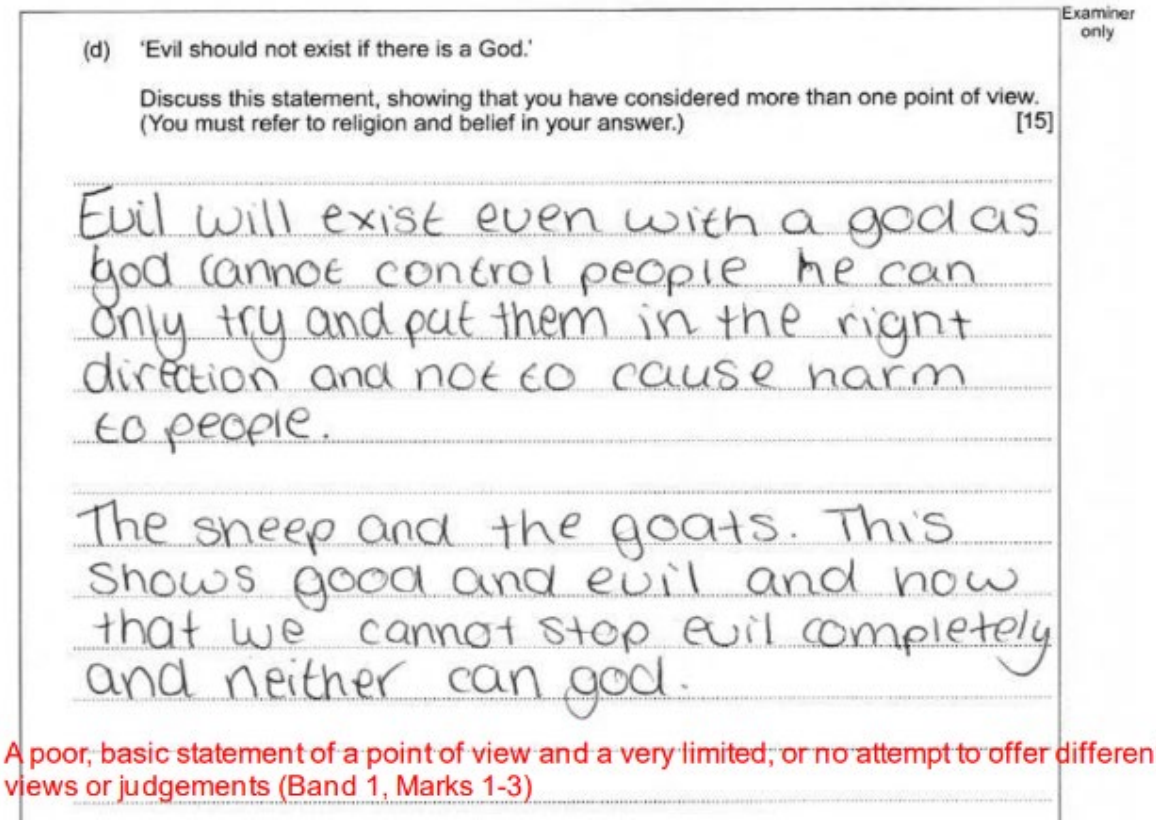
Question 'd' for 2d on Component 1 in Route A and 1d on Component 1 Route B

Band	Band Descriptor	Mark Total
5	An excellent, highly detailed analysis and evaluation of the issue based on detailed knowledge of religion, religious teaching and moral reasoning to formulate judgements and present alternative or different viewpoints. An excellent understanding of how belief influences individuals, communities and societies. An excellent, highly detailed consideration of non-religious beliefs, such as those held by Humanists and Atheists. Uses and interprets religious/specialist language, terms and sources of wisdom and authority extensively, accurately and appropriately.	13 – 15
4	A very good, detailed analysis and evaluation of the issue based on accurate knowledge of religion, religious teaching and moral reasoning to formulate judgements and present alternative or different viewpoints. A very good understanding of how belief influences individuals, communities and societies A very good, detailed consideration of non-religious beliefs, such as those held by Humanists and Atheists. Uses and interprets religious/specialist language, terms and sources of wisdom and authority appropriately and in detail.	10 – 12
3	A good, generally detailed analysis and evaluation of the issue based on a generally accurate knowledge of religion, religious teaching and moral reasoning to formulate reasonable judgements and recognise alternative or different viewpoints linked to religion and belief. A good understanding of how belief influences individuals, communities and societies A good, reasonably detailed consideration of non-religious beliefs, such as those held by Humanists and Atheists. Uses and interprets some religious/specialist language, terms and/or sources of wisdom and authority	7 – 9
2	Limited statement(s) of more than one viewpoint based on limited knowledge of religion, religious teaching and moral reasoning to formulate judgements. A limited understanding of how belief influences individuals, communities and societies. A limited consideration of non-religious beliefs, such as those held by Humanists and Atheists. Uses limited religious/specialist language, terms and/or few sources of wisdom and authority	4 – 6
1	A poor, basic statement of a point of view and a very limited attempt, or no attempt to formulate judgements or offer alternative or different viewpoints. Little attempt or no attempt made to demonstrate how belief influences individuals, communities and societies. A very basic consideration or no consideration of non-religious beliefs, such as those held by Humanists and Atheists. Poor use or no use of religious/specialist language, terms and/or sources of wisdom and authority.	1 – 3
0	No relevant point of view stated.	0

Assessment of spelling, punctuation and the accurate use of grammar:

Band	Performance descriptions
High performance 5–6 marks	• Learners spell and punctuate with consistent accuracy • Learners use rules of grammar with effective control of meaning overall
Intermediate performance 3–4 marks	• Learners spell and punctuate with considerable accuracy • Learners use rules of grammar with general control of meaning overall
Threshold performance 1–2 marks	• Learners spell and punctuate with reasonable accuracy • Learners use rules of grammar with some control of meaning and any errors do not significantly hinder meaning overall
0	• The learner writes nothing • The learner's response does not relate to the question • The learner's achievement in SPaG does not reach the threshold performance Band, for example errors in spelling, punctuation and grammar severely hinder meaning

Examples



Examiner only

(d) 'Evil should not exist if there is a God.'

Discuss this statement, showing that you have considered more than one point of view. (You must refer to religion and belief in your answer.) [15]

Evil will exist even with a god as god cannot control people he can only try and put them in the right direction and not to cause harm to people.

The sheep and the goats. This shows good and evil and how that we cannot stop evil completely and neither can god.

A poor, basic statement of a point of view and a very limited, or no attempt to offer different views or judgements (Band 1, Marks 1-3)

Band 1: 3 marks

This answer includes one reason with a slight justification. It is one-sided and brief, meaning it does not reach band 2.

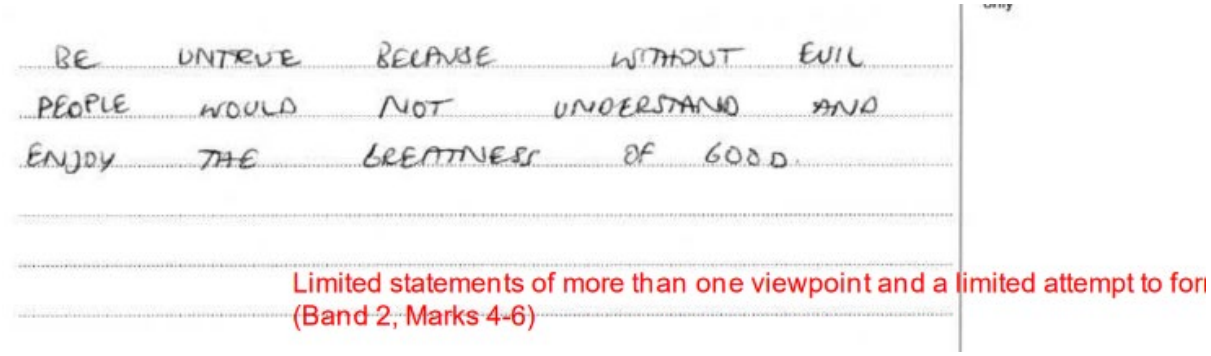
(d) 'Evil should not exist if there is a God.'

Discuss this statement, showing that you have considered more than one point of view. (You must refer to religion and belief in your answer.) [15]

MANY

CHRISTIANS BELIEVE THAT EVIL SHOULD NOT EXIST IF THERE IS A GOD. THIS IS BECAUSE GOD IS BELIEVED TO BE OMNIBEVOLENT AND OMNIPOTENT, WHICH WOULD MEAN THAT GOD SHOULD REMOVE ALL EVIL FROM THE WORLD BECAUSE HE IS ALL LOVING. HE IS ALSO BELIEVED TO BE ALL POWERFULL SO HE HAS ALL THE POWER AND ABILITY TO STOP ALL EVIL. GOD IS ALSO SEEN AS OMNISCIENT WHICH MEANS THAT HE IS ALL-KNOWING, SO HE KNOWS HOW TO STOP ALL EVIL.

HOWEVER MANY BELIEVE THAT THIS STATEMENT IS FALSE BECAUSE HUMANS ALL HAVE FREE WILL, THIS MEANS THAT ALL THE EVIL THAT HAPPENS WE BRING ONTO OURSELVES, THIS IS SHOWN IN THE BIBLE WHEN EVE COMMITS THE FIRST SIN. ALSO THIS STATEMENT IS SEEN TO



Band 2: 6 marks

This response includes two different points of view, using some key words and a Bible reference to justify the views given. The first paragraph shows a general understanding but doesn't apply it clearly and directly to the question. There is no clear indication as to which reason the candidate thinks is more persuasive, so the skills of analysis and evaluation are limited, showing it to be a band 2 answer.

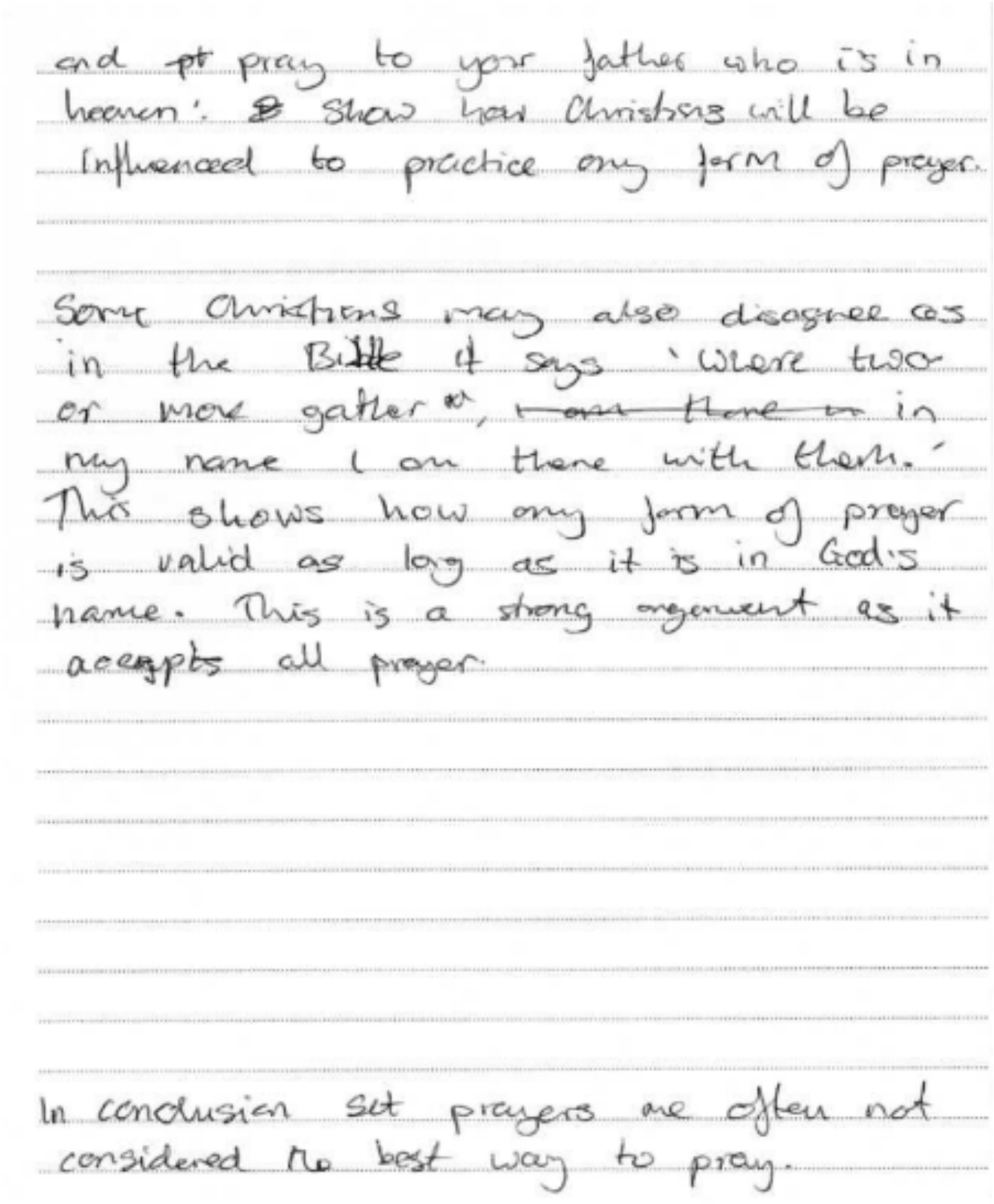
(d) 'Using set prayers is the best way for Christians to pray.'

Discuss this statement, showing that you have considered more than one point of view. (You must refer to religion and belief in your answer.) [15]

Some may agree as it gives people structure when praying to God. But some would want it to be personal.

Many Catholics would agree with this because they perform mass (Eucharist) every sunday as a part of set prayer. This is the best way to pray as it gives christians set times to remember the story of Jesus. Additionally Jesus told his diciples to 'share' his 'body' with the world in ~~mass~~ remembrance. This is a weak argument because there is no requirement to ~~do~~ perform Eucharist every week so set prayers is not always necessary.

Some Christians would disagree with this statement as they believe that prayer is for the purpose of communication with God. This ~~be~~ means they may want to do ~~thanks~~ thanks giving to communicate with God. 'Go to your room, close the door,


and pt pray to your father who is in heaven'. & Show how Christians will be influenced to practice any form of prayer.

Some Christians may also disagree as in the Bible it says 'Where two or more gather ~~are there~~ in my name I am there with them.' This shows how any form of prayer is valid as long as it is in God's name. This is a strong argument as it accepts all prayer.

In conclusion set prayers are often not considered the best way to pray.

Band 3: 7 marks

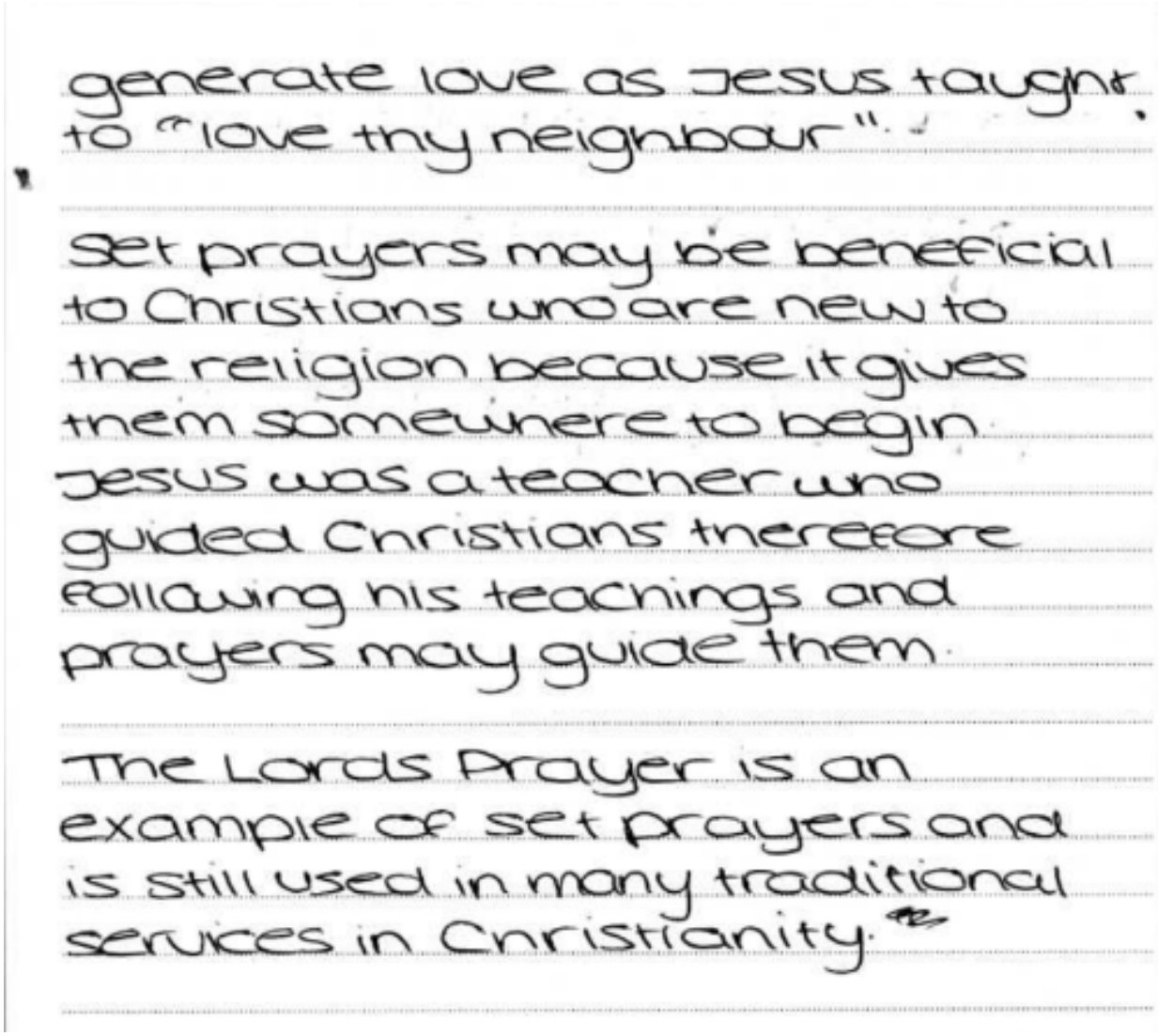
This is a good, generally detailed analysis and evaluation of the issue, placing it in band 3. It is at the bottom of band 3 because the first paragraph is not focused on the specific demands of the question: set prayer. It references set prayers being used in the Eucharist service but does not exemplify this, nor does it use the set prayers within the Eucharist service to make a specific point about whether or not set prayers are the best way to pray. So, it shows some knowledge and understanding of set prayer but doesn't use it well to evaluate the statement. The second argument about other types of prayer is better.

(d) 'Using set prayers is the best way for Christians to pray.'

Discuss this statement, showing that you have considered more than one point of view. (You must refer to religion and belief in your answer.) [15]

Set prayers are often in Liturgical worship, often taken place by more traditional Christians such as Roman Catholics who have a very set structure of worship. Set prayers are often done at the Eucharist or Baptism in order to celebrate. Set prayers will often have specific aims and therefore be good for Christians with these aims.

Individual worship may be seen as more beneficial for those Christians who would like to form a more personal relationship with God. Prayer has many ~~benefits~~ aims that different Christians may want to benefit from for example penance; asking for forgiveness. Christians may also prefer to use individual ~~pe~~ prayer to


generate love as Jesus taught to "love thy neighbour".

Set prayers may be beneficial to Christians who are new to the religion because it gives them somewhere to begin. Jesus was a teacher who guided Christians therefore following his teachings and prayers may guide them.

The Lords Prayer is an example of set prayers and is still used in many traditional services in Christianity.

Band 3: 8 marks

This is also a good, generally detailed analysis and evaluation of the issue, placing it in band 3, but this is slightly higher up in the band due to its focus on addressing the question. The first paragraph reads like AO1 content but does show knowledge and understanding that is later used. Had this content been used better to analyse and evaluate the statement from the start it may have placed in the higher bands. It does include knowledge of key terms such as 'liturgical worship' and the end of the paragraph begins to relate the content to the question. The second paragraph gives two reasons why Christians may think individual prayer is better, again supported by key terms such as 'penance'. Finally, it returns to set prayers and gives an argument as to why they may be better (more beneficial). This answer would require more evaluation and/or more specific and detailed justification for arguments for it to be placed in a higher band.

d) "Using set prayers is the best way for Christians to pray." This statement could be controversial to some Christians as prayer comes in many forms within the religion and some people may choose to worship in different ways to others. The reasons for Christians to pray are: Adoration towards God; Confession of sins; Thanksgiving for God's benevolence; Supplication for ones self; And intercession for others. People may choose to practice these things in different manners. For example, Quakers believe in liturgical worship in a Church in which they sit in silence and pray to God. In this practice they may choose to use set prayers as they could value them as the best way to pray to God and practice the previously mentioned things.

Other Christians may practice different forms of prayer such as Evangelical worship which is very non-liturgical and focuses more on spreading the gospel to others than anything else. This kind of worship does not follow any kind of set prayer as it is more spontaneous and joyous to partake in. Evangelical worshippers may believe that their way of practicing prayer is superior as it is far less structured and they may believe that they can show greater adoration for God in that manner. Evangelical worshippers may believe that by spreading the gospel, they are still fulfilling all of the reasons for prayer in a more exciting, positive way. They are also following the direct word of Jesus who, in the bible, told his disciples to go and spread the gospel to others to save them and convert them to the Christian faith.

In conclusion, Christians have many different ideas on how to pray to God. Some Christians, such as Quakers, may believe that set prayers are the superior method as they follow a set structure and fulfill all the reasons to pray to God. However, other Christians such as Evangelist, may believe that it is better to be more spontaneous in prayer as it can not only help to spread the gospel to others, but it can help to show a greater, personal sense of adoration towards God.

A good, generally detailed analysis and evaluation that recognises different viewpoints and gives reasonable judgements (Band 3, Marks 7-9)

Band 3: 9 marks

This candidate has included a range of arguments, supported by a range of types of prayers and reasons for prayer. They include a variety of key terms and use them accurately. This is a band 3 answer as it is ‘generally accurate’ as there is a fair amount of content about Quakers which is incorrect. It fits best in band 3 but the top of band 3.

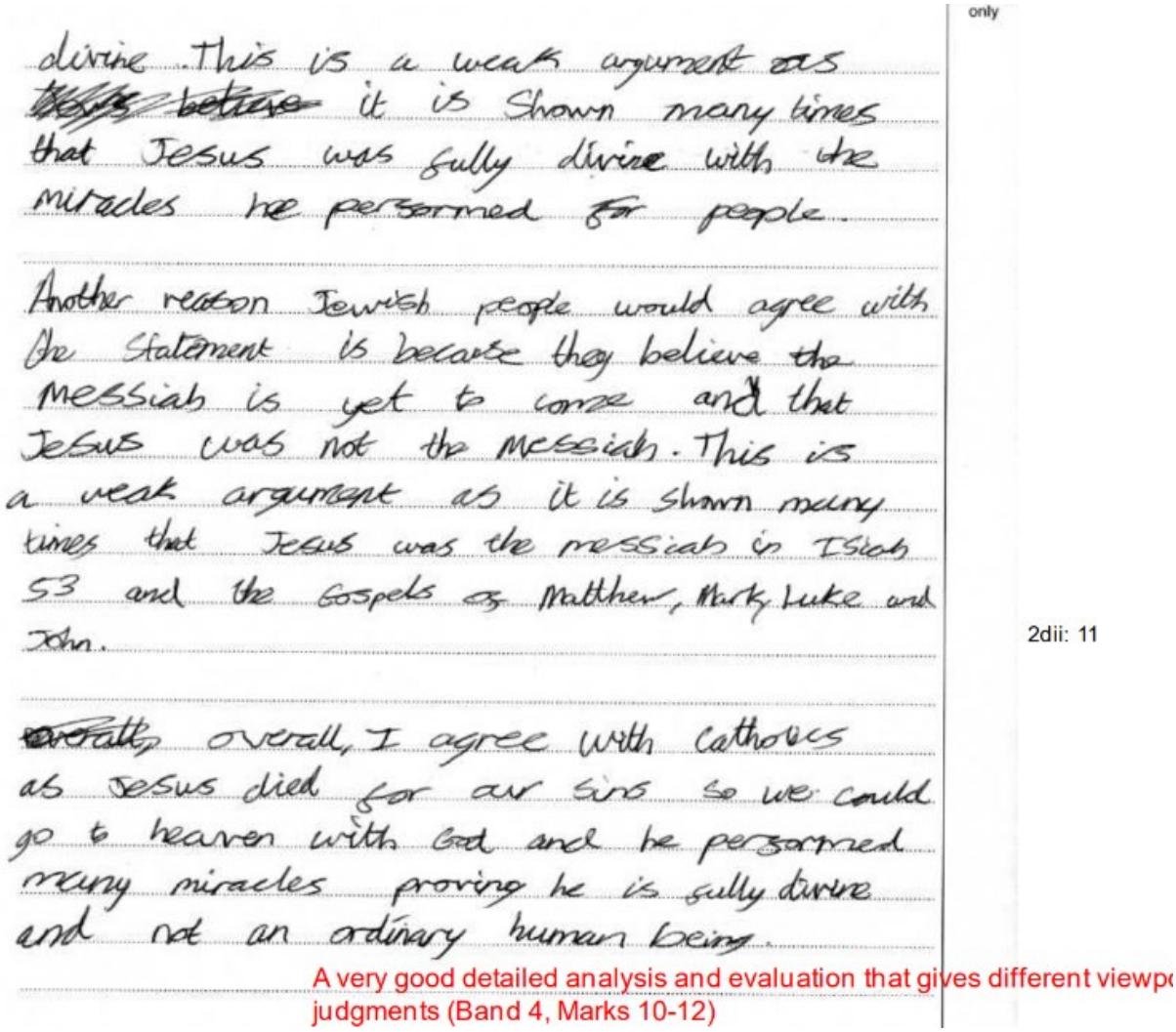
(ii) 'Jesus was nothing more than an ordinary human being.'

Discuss this statement, showing that you have considered more than one point of view.
(You must refer to religion and belief in your answer.) [15]

Catholics would disagree with this statement as they believe that Jesus is God in human form who came down to earth to save us from our sins, Isiah 53. Catholics would argue that it's impossible for Jesus to be ~~human~~ an ordinary human being as he is God, fully divine and fully human. This is a strong argument as he saved us from sins by dying on the cross proving he's more than an ordinary humans

Catholics would also argue that Jesus couldn't be an ordinary human being as he performed many miracles such as healing a man with leprosy and making a blind man see again. This is a strong argument as no ordinary human could perform miracles like this, only God can.

However Jews would argue that Jesus was just a regular human being who just ~~help~~ helped those in need. Jews don't believe Jesus to be the messiah or that he was fully



Band 4: 11 marks

This is a detailed, well-written answer that includes a few arguments supported by reference to scripture. Arguments from a Catholic and a Jewish perspective are given and there is some evaluation of arguments throughout and in a final conclusion. It fits in band 4 and not band 5 because it is quite repetitive; there is a lot of mention of miracles rather than having a variety of counter-responses to the Jewish points made. Some key concepts are understood, such as Jesus being 'fully God and fully man' but this could be further developed for band 5 by using subject-specific terminology such as 'hypostatic union'.

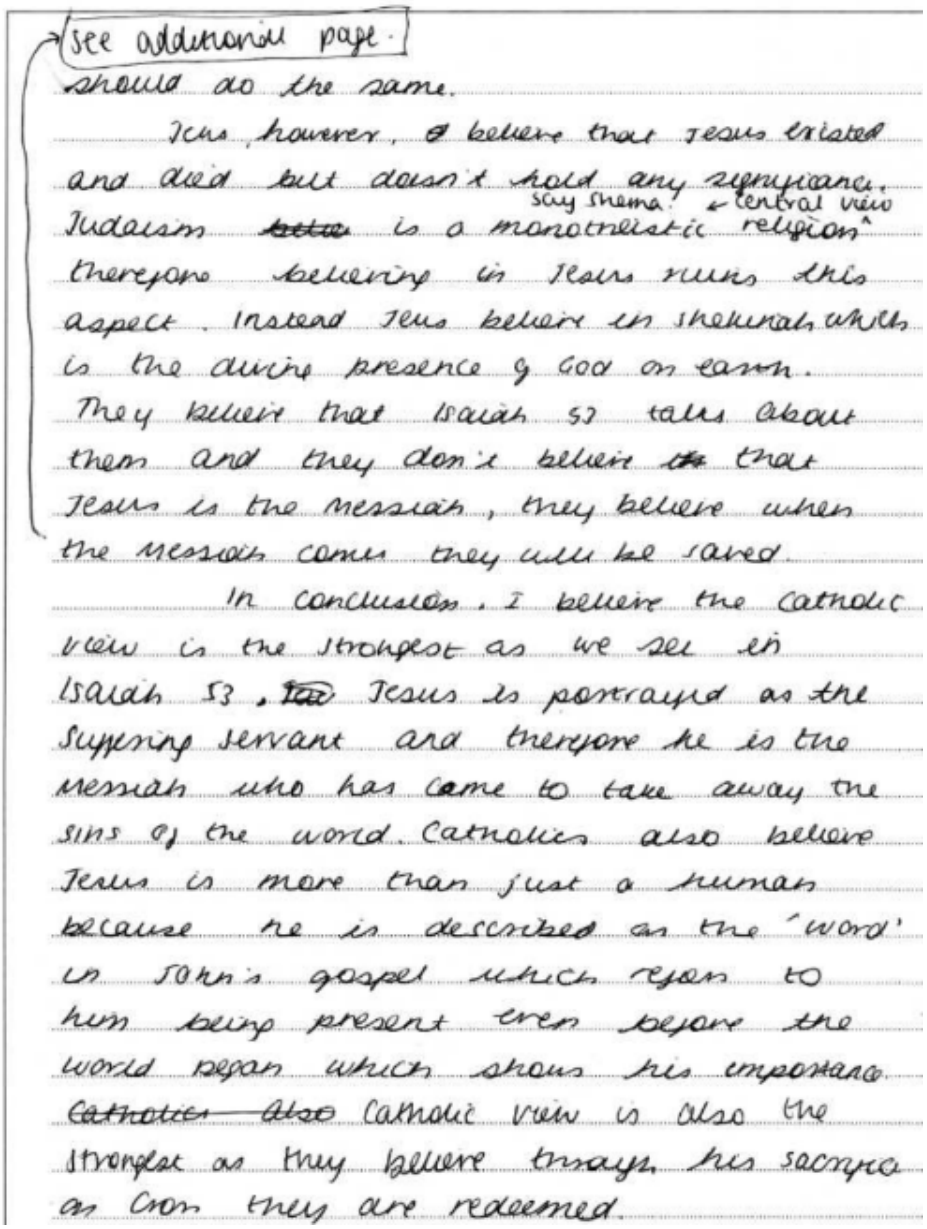
(ii) 'Jesus was nothing more than an ordinary human being.'

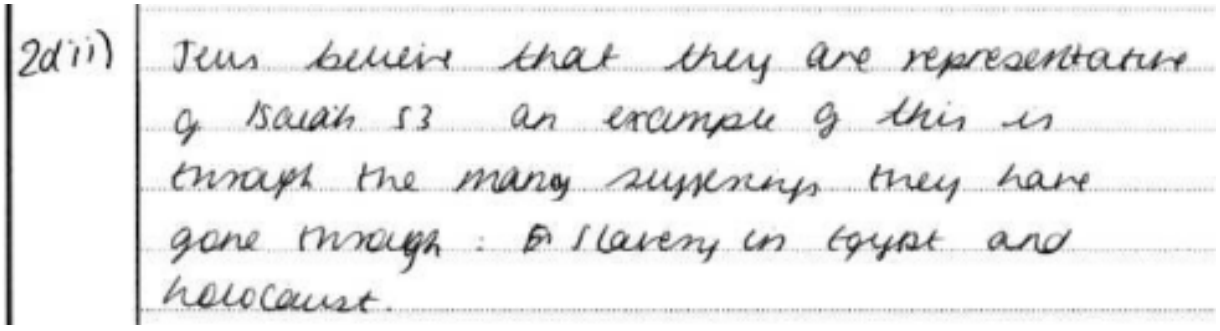
Discuss this statement, showing that you have considered more than one point o view.
(You must refer to religion and belief in your answer.) [1

Jesus I disagree with the statement as Catholics believe that through Jesus we have all been redeemed.

Catholics disagree with the statement as they believe he was the incarnation of God this means God emptied himself to become human in the form of Jesus which shows his omnibenevolence. This is further explored in the Kenosis Hymn where St Paul states that Jesus is in the incarnate of God therefore His life and teachings come from God and therefore he is sacred.

Catholics also disagree with the statement as they believe that Jesus makes up the Trinity therefore he is omnipotent. The idea of Trinity is ~~pro~~ by St Augustine in De Trinitate where he describes God, Jesus & and Holy spirit in terms of love. This shows that Jesus is the son of God. as the trinity makes up the three aspects of God. Furthermore, Catholics argue that through Jesus we are able to learn more about God's teachings as he forgave our sins when he died on cross showing that we too





Band 5: 15 marks

This is an outstanding answer. It contains a variety of well-supported arguments to thoroughly evaluate the statement. The range of key concepts such as kenosis is impressive and there are many references to scripture to justify arguments stated. It is written in a sophisticated way and well worthy of full marks.